

IN SEARCH OF UNITY
Rahul Gandhi during the 'Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra' in Bihar's Araria, Jan. 29

ALLIES WERE UPSET THAT RATHER THAN MAKE IT A COLLECTIVE MISSION, CONGRESS LAUNCHED THE YATRA UNILATERALLY, WITH RAHUL AS ITS FACE

that AAP is open to seat-sharing with the Congress in Haryana for the Lok Sabha polls, the ED interrogated former Congress CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda for alleged irregularities in land acquisition in Manesar.

Similarly, Mamata's decision to go solo has fuelled conspiracy theories about her desperation to save her nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, who is also caught in the probe agencies' net over multiple corruption charges. Many insiders, too, are wondering about the party's "inactivity" given that the Lok Sabha polls are a few months away. There is no sign of any strategy, campaign ideas or narrative to combat the BJP. The Indian Political Action Committee (IPAC), the campaign advisor to the TMC, was supposed to deploy one person each for the 294 assemblies right after Durga Puja in October, but not a single person has been stationed so far. This, when a survey by the agency for the TMC showed that about 53 per cent of Bengal's electorate wanted to see Modi as the prime minister and Mamata's support base was half that of Modi.

WHERE IS THE NARRATIVE?

Along with the lack of a credible face to take on the Modi-led BJP, the lack of a credible narrative has played a part in undermining I.N.D.I.A.'s cause. Since its inception, the alliance has appeared as an inchoate group of regional chieftains united by nothing more than the common desire to see Modi's back. And this against an adversary who is set to step into the electoral arena with all guns blazing, claiming to have delivered on all fronts, be it development (making India the world's third-largest economy), enhancing India's global stature (a successfully hosted G20 summit), Hindutva (inauguration of the Ram temple in Ayodhya) or nationalism (abrogation of Article 370 in J&K). The brief spark that the demand for a national caste census may have provided now stands firmly extinguished with Nitish's exit.

I.N.D.I.A. partners could not even come up with a unified response to the one plank that everyone knew the BJP would ratchet up with the inauguration of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, with the elaborate *pran pratishtha* ceremony. So, while Kejriwal welcomed the inauguration of the temple and even promised to follow the principles of Ram Rajya, the Congress response was divided. Its top leadership stayed away from the event to underline its secular ethos, but Congress-ruled Himachal Pradesh declared a holiday to celebrate the occasion. Responding to a question about the "Ram wave" in the wake of the Ayodhya spectacle, Rahul dismissed the suggestion and said he'll go to the people of India with a construct of justice based on five pillars—equal participation, women, youth, farmers and workers.

With Nitish gone, it also remains to be seen which way the gains of his caste survey will flow. Following its announcement, Rahul had raised the pitch for rights proportionate to the share of population. It was to be the Opposition's biggest electoral ammunition against the BJP. With it, the alliance hoped to dent the BJP's OBC (Other Backward Class) vote bank and blunt the edge it gave the saffron party in the past two Lok Sabha elections as well as several assembly polls. That advantage has now swung the